

DIVERSITY AND REPRESENTATION IN THE SEVENTEENTH WEST BENGAL LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY: AN ANALYSIS OF GENDER AND SOCIAL GROUP PRESENCE

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Data Source

RTI filed by Sabir Ahamed

Preface

The Constitution of India clearly distributes powers between the Union and the States through the Seventh Schedule, which comprises the Union List, State List, and Concurrent List. States deal with the key subjects such as police, public order, health, agriculture, and local governance, making them central to everyday governance.

Amid the ongoing debates around SIR in West Bengal, the state is approaching the forthcoming Assembly elections. Several political parties have already announced their candidates. These candidate lists offer an important lens to assess the extent of commitment towards India's pluralistic social fabric.

The State Assembly plays a pivotal role in the implementation of social welfare programmes, as state governments are primarily responsible for designing, adapting, and executing policies on the ground. In this context, the composition of the Assembly becomes critically important. Representation of diverse social groups ensures that policy priorities reflect the needs and realities of all sections of society.

Drawing on Anne Phillips' concept of the "politics of presence," there is a strong theoretical argument for inclusive institutions to counter systemic exclusion. Representation is not merely symbolic; it fundamentally shapes whose voices are heard in decision-making spaces.

Using this framework, the report maps the representation of different social groups in the last Assembly. While Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) have constitutionally mandated representation, Muslims remain significantly underrepresented—both as Members of the Assembly and as members and chairpersons of key committees.

According to the 2011 Census (though dated), Muslims constitute nearly 27% of West Bengal's population. Yet, their voices remain largely absent from spaces of policy planning and institutional power. This brief attempts to empirically capture this "conspicuous absence" across key decision-making domains, despite their substantial electoral significance under successive regimes, including both the Left Front and the Trinamool Congress.

It is also important to note that while the number of women members in the West Bengal Legislative Assembly has increased over the decades, they continue to be underrepresented in influential committees where critical decisions are shaped.

This report is based on data from the Election Commission and information obtained through RTI by one of the contributors. One of its central aims is to foreground issues of social justice through the lens of representation, guided by the principles of the politics of presence.

This research is the culmination of the sustained efforts of a team of dedicated young researchers. We hope it will serve as a valuable resource for election coverage, policy discussions, and academic work. We would appreciate your support in furthering this research initiative.

Key Insights

The following figures summarise the representation of Muslims, Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and Women across the 42 committees of the Seventeenth West Bengal Legislative Assembly (2021–2025 term), based on RTI data.

Committee Seat Share (Unique Members, 256 total seats)

14.8% **Muslim committee seat share** (38 of 256 unique seats) — against 27% population share

23.8% **SC committee seat share** (61 of 256) — roughly in line with 29.3% population share

4.7% **ST committee seat share** (12 of 256) — below ~6% population share

13.3% **Women's committee seat share** (34 of 256) — against 50% population share

Chairperson Representation (38 Chairpersons across all committees)

7 of 38 **Muslim Chairpersons** (18.4%) — below their 27% population share

5 of 38 **SC Chairpersons** (13.2%)

0 of 38 **ST Chairpersons** (0%) — no ST member chairs any of the 42 committees

4 of 38 **Women Chairpersons** (10.5%) — against 50% population share

Key Findings

- 2 committees have zero Muslim members: the Standing Committee on Backward Classes Welfare and the Standing Committee on School Education.
- 16 of 42 committees have zero ST members.
- 8 committees have zero women members, including the Standing Committees on Health & Family Welfare, Higher Education, School Education, Finance & Planning and Land and Land Reforms.
- Excluding the Standing Committee on Minority Affairs (which has high Muslim membership by design), the Muslim seat share across the remaining 41 committees falls to 14.3% — a gap of nearly 13 percentage points below the Muslim population share.

1. Muslim Representation in the West Bengal Assembly: 1962 to 2021

The table below shows Muslim MLA share at each election since 1962, compared with the interpolated Muslim population share for that year (derived from Census data 1941 to 2011). The trend reveals persistent under-representation, with a brief improvement in 2011 followed by a sharp reversal.

Election Year	Muslim MLAs (%)	Muslim Pop. (%)	Gap (pop. minus MLA)
1962	11.1%	20.1%	Under-represented by 9.0 pp
1967	13.6%	20.3%	Under-represented by 6.7 pp
1969	13.6%	20.4%	Under-represented by 6.8 pp
1971	14.3%	20.5%	Under-represented by 6.2 pp
1977	13.3%	21.1%	Under-represented by 7.8 pp
1982	14.6%	21.7%	Under-represented by 7.1 pp
1987	13.3%	22.8%	Under-represented by 9.5 pp
1991	14.6%	23.6%	Under-represented by 9.0 pp
1996	15%	24.4%	Under-represented by 9.4 pp
2001	13.9%	25.2%	Under-represented by 11.3 pp
2006	15%	26.1%	Under-represented by 11.1 pp
2011	20.4%	27%	Under-represented by 6.6 pp
2016	19.7%	27%	Under-represented by 7.3 pp
2021	14.7%	27%	Under-represented by 12.3 pp

SC+ST Representation in the West Bengal Assembly: 1962 to 2021

The table below shows SC+ST MLA share at each election since 1962, compared with the interpolated SC+ST population share for that year (derived from Census data 1961 to 2011). SC+ST representation has tracked population share closely, with modest gaps in either direction. The 2021 election saw notable over-representation at 34.2%, significantly above the 29.3% population share.

Election Year	SC+ST MLAs (%)	SC+ST Pop. (%)	Gap (pop. minus MLA)
1962	26.8%	25.8%	Over-represented by 1.0 pp
1967	26.4%	26.9%	Under-represented by 0.5 pp
1969	25.7%	27.3%	Under-represented by 1.6 pp
1971	26.3%	27.7%	Under-represented by 1.4 pp
1977	27.0%	28.0%	Under-represented by 1.0 pp
1982	27.4%	28.3%	Under-represented by 0.9 pp
1987	27.1%	28.8%	Under-represented by 1.7 pp
1991	28.1%	29.2%	Under-represented by 1.1 pp
1996	30.1%	28.9%	Over-represented by 1.2 pp
2001	28.8%	28.5%	Over-represented by 0.3 pp
2006	27.2%	28.9%	Under-represented by 1.7 pp
2011	30.4%	29.3%	Over-represented by 1.1 pp

Election Year	SC+ST MLAs (%)	SC+ST Pop. (%)	Gap (pop. minus MLA)
2016	29.8%	29.3%	Over-represented by 0.5 pp
2021	34.2%	29.3%	Over-represented by 4.9 pp

Figure 1: Muslim and SC+ST Representation vs Population Share, 1962 to 2021

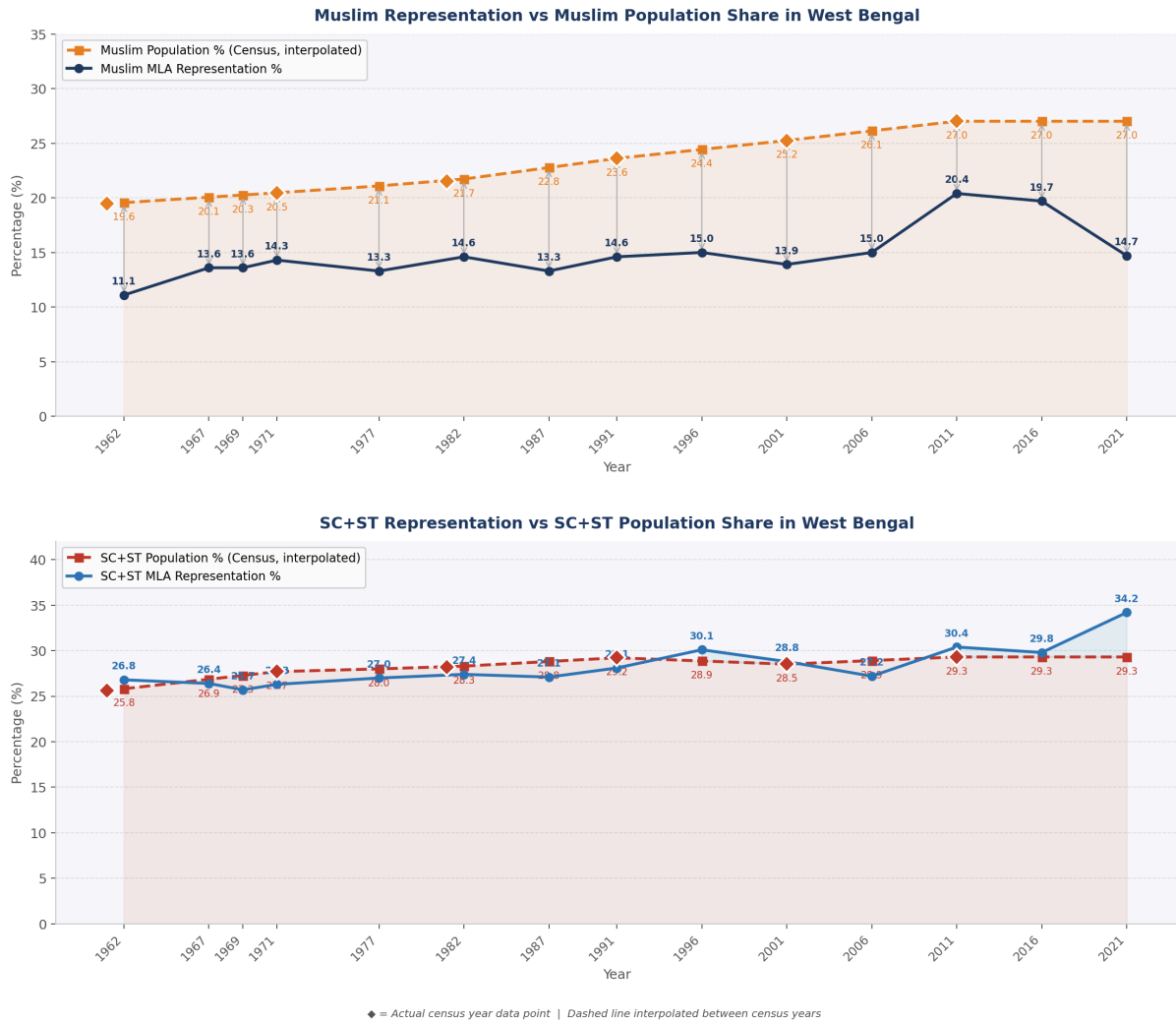
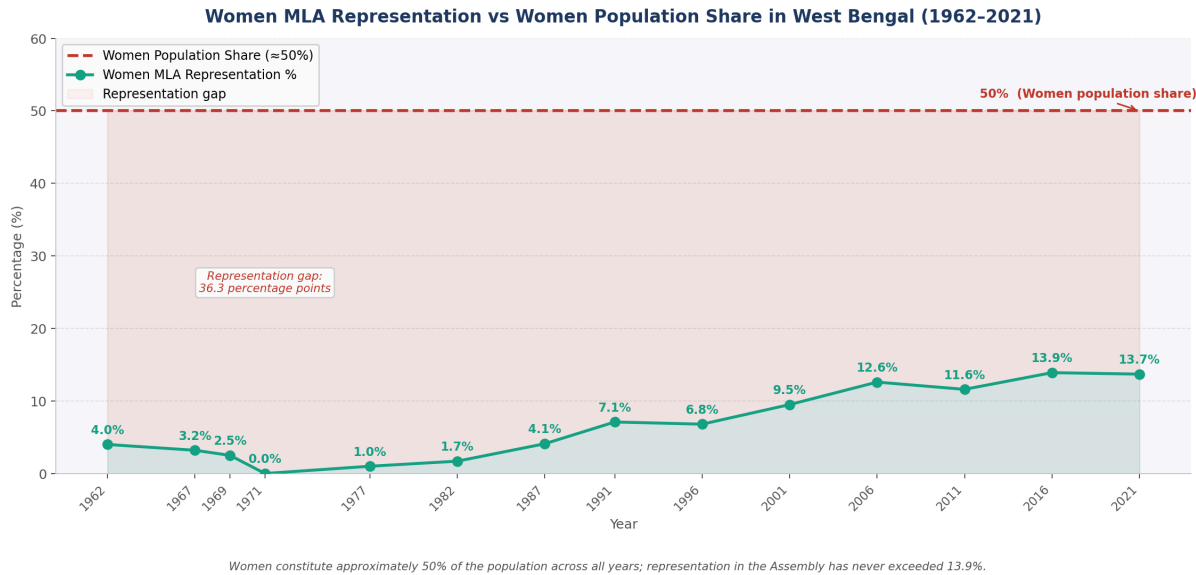


Figure 2: Women MLA Representation vs Women Population Share, 1962 to 2021



2. Overall Committee Membership (2021 to 2025 Term)

This analysis covers **256 unique members** identified across 42 committees after reconciling over 57 spelling variants in the source data. Figures are based on unique individuals unless otherwise stated.

Demographic Breakdown -- Unique Members

Muslim	SC	ST	SC + ST	Female	Male
14.8% (38/256)	23.8% (61/256)	4.7% (12/256)	28.5% (73/256)	13.3% (34/256)	86.7% (222/256)

Muslim Share Excluding the Standing Committee on Minority Affairs

The Standing Committee on Minority Affairs has a high Muslim membership by design. On a seat-count basis, excluding it, Muslims hold **14.3% of committee seats** (97 of 679) -- far below the 27% population share. SC share across the remaining 41 committees is **23.4%**, and ST share is **5%**.

All 42 Committees (seat basis)	Excl. Minority Affairs (seat basis)
Muslim: 15.6% SC: 23.1% ST: 4.9%	Muslim: 14.3% SC: 23.4% ST: 5%

Top 5 Most Common Surnames

Rank	Surname	Count (% share)
1	Roy	14 (5.5%)
2	Ghosh	12 (4.7%)
3	Mondal	9 (3.5%)
4	Saha	8 (3.1%)
5	Chatterjee	7 (2.7%)

3. Chairmen and Chairpersons

38 unique individuals hold Chairman or Chairperson positions across the 42 committees.

Demographic Breakdown

Muslim	SC	ST	SC + ST	Female	Male
18.4% (7/38)	13.2% (5/38)	0% (0/38)	13.2% (5/38)	10.5% (4/38)	89.5% (34/38)

Top Surnames Among Chairpersons

Rank	Surname	Count (% share)
1	Banerjee	3 (7.9%)
2	Roy	3 (7.9%)
3	Mondal	2 (5.3%)
4	Molla	2 (5.3%)
5	Saha	2 (5.3%)

Full List of Chairpersons

Name	Surname	Gender	Caste	Religion
Shri Biman Banerjee	Banerjee	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Suman Kanjilal	Kanjilal	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Apurba Sarkar	Sarkar	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Dr. Sudipto Roy	Roy	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Dr. Saumen Kumar Mahapatra	Mahapatra	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Humayun Kabir	Kabir	Male	General	Muslim
Smt. Supti Pandey	Pandey	Female	General	Non-Muslim
Dr. Asish Banerjee	Banerjee	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Dr. Ratna De Naq	Naq	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Pannalal Halder	Halder	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Tapas Banerjee	Banerjee	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Kallol Khan	Khan	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Md. Nawsad Siddique	Siddique	Male	General	Muslim
Smt. Asima Patra	Patra	Female	SC	Non-Muslim
Shri Debabrata Mazumdar	Mazumdar	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Rafikul Islam Mondal	Mondal	Male	General	Muslim
Shri Kalipada Mandal	Mandal	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Dr. Nirmal Maji	Maji	Male	SC	Non-Muslim
Shri Ashok Kumar Deb	Deb	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Samir Kumar Jana	Jana	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Saokat Molla	Molla	Male	General	Muslim
Shri Abdul Khaleque Molla	Molla	Male	General	Muslim
Smt. Nayna Bandyopadhyay	Bandyopadhyay	Female	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Dinen Roy	Roy	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Tapash Chatterjee	Chatterjee	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Kanai Chandra Mondal	Mondal	Male	SC	Non-Muslim
Shri Madan Mitra	Mitra	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Rukbanur Rahman	Rahman	Male	General	Muslim
Shri Khageswar Roy	Roy	Male	SC	Non-Muslim
Smt. Firdousi Begum	Begum	Female	General	Muslim
Shri Swarna Kamal Saha	Saha	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Tapan Dasgupta	Dasgupta	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Pundarikakshya Saha	Saha	Male	General	Non-Muslim

Dr. Asok Kumar Chattopadhyay	Chattopadhyay	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Alok Kumar Majhi	Majhi	Male	SC	Non-Muslim
Shri Raju Chakraborty (Raj)	Chakraborty	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Samar Mukherjee	Mukherjee	Male	General	Non-Muslim
Shri Ajit Maity	Maity	Male	General	Non-Muslim

4. Detailed Committee Breakdown

Each entry shows absolute counts for total members, Muslims, SC members, ST members, Females, and Males.

Business Advisory Committee (as on 1.10.2024)

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
21	2	1	0	1	20

Committee on Public Accounts

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	2	4	0	1	19

Committee on Public Undertakings

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	2	2	0	4	16

Committee on Estimates

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	3	3	1	0	20

Committee on Local Fund Accounts

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
19	3	1	0	4	15

Committee on Papers Laid on the Table

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	5	7	2	1	19

Committee on Petitions

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
19	1	7	2	2	17

Committee of Privileges

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
19	4	4	0	2	17

Committee on Government Assurances

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
19	4	2	0	4	15

Committee on Subordinate Legislation

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
19	1	7	1	1	18

Committee on Rules

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
17	1	0	0	2	15

Committee on the Entitlements of the Members

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
18	4	3	0	0	18

House Committee

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	2	7	2	5	15

Library Committee

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	3	7	2	1	19

Committee on Reforms and Functioning of the Committee System

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	5	6	0	3	17

Committee on Bidhayak Elaka Umayan Prakaalpa

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
20	5	5	2	3	17

Standing Committee on Home, Personnel & Administrative Reforms, Correctional Administration, Law and Judicial

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	3	4	0	4	10

Standing Committee on Finance & Planning

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	1	2	0	0	14

Standing Committee on Higher Education

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	4	5	0	0	15

Standing Committee on School Education

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	0	4	2	0	14

Standing Committee on Health & Family Welfare

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	1	3	0	0	15

Standing Committee on Panchayats & Rural Development and Sundarban Affairs

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	1	5	0	4	11

Standing Committee on Irrigation & Waterways and Water Resources Investigation & Development

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	1	4	1	1	13

Standing Committee on Environment, Forests & Tourism

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	2	4	1	2	13

Standing Committee on Power and Non-Conventional Energy Sources

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	3	3	1	0	14

Standing Committee on Women & Child Development and Social Welfare

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	2	4	0	15	0

Standing Committee on Agriculture, Agricultural Marketing and Food Processing Industries & Horticulture

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	4	6	0	0	15

Committee on Urban Development and Municipal Affairs

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
16	1	0	0	1	15

Standing Committee on Industry, Commerce & Enterprises

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	1	4	0	1	14

Standing Committee on Labour

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	2	1	1	2	12

Committee on Fisheries and Animal Resources Development

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	3	2	2	2	12

Standing Committee on Backward Classes Welfare

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	0	9	6	2	13

Standing Committee on Minority Affairs

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	11	1	0	2	13

Standing Committee on Transport

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	3	1	2	1	14

Standing Committee on Public Works and Public Health Engineering

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	1	6	1	0	15

Standing Committee on Food & Supplies

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	5	4	1	1	14

Standing Committee on Self Help Group and Self Employment

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	2	4	0	15	0

Standing Committee on Information Technology and Technical Education

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
14	2	3	1	2	12

Standing Committee on Housing, Fire & Emergency Services and Disaster Management

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	2	4	0	0	15

Standing Committee on Information & Cultural Affairs and Youth Services & Sports

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	1	2	1	1	14

Standing Committee on Land and Land Reforms

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	2	4	0	0	15

Standing Committee on Co-Operation and Consumer Affairs

Total	Muslim	SC	ST	Female	Male
15	3	5	2	1	14

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